

RAPID CORTEX

NFC Tag Installation Guide

Rapid Cortex Campus · Rapid Cortex Venue

Step-by-step guide to programming and attaching NFC tags to safety reporting signs

15 minutes

No technical skills needed

Works on any smartphone

Overview

An NFC (Near Field Communication) tag is a small sticker — about the size of a coin — that contains a tiny chip. When a smartphone is held near it, the phone automatically opens a web page. No camera, no app download, no typing required.

For Rapid Cortex, each NFC tag is programmed with a unique reporting URL tied to your agency and location. When someone taps the sign, they go directly to the safety reporting form for that exact location. The report is received instantly by your security team.

NOTE NFC tags and QR codes on the same sign point to the same URL. They work identically — NFC is just faster for users with newer phones.

What You Need

Purchase these items before installation. Everything is available on Amazon.

Item	Details	Where to Buy
NTAG213 NFC stickers	Pack of 100 • Round or square • White finish	Amazon — search “NTAG213 NFC stickers” (~\$15–20 per 100)
Smartphone	iPhone 7 or newer • Any Android with NFC (most phones since 2014)	You already have this
NFC Tools app	Free • iOS and Android • Publisher: wakdev	App Store / Google Play
Reporting URL	Generated in the Rapid Cortex admin dashboard for each sign location	Rapid Cortex dashboard
Permanent marker (optional)	For labeling tag backs with location name	Any office supply store
Isopropyl alcohol wipes (optional)	For cleaning sign surface before adhering tag	Amazon or pharmacy

TIP NTAG213 is the most compatible NFC chip type. Do not use NTAG215 or NTAG216 — they work but cost more for no benefit in this use case.

1

Get the Reporting URL

Log in to Rapid Cortex and generate the URL for this sign location

Each physical sign location gets its own unique URL. You generate this in the Rapid Cortex admin dashboard.

1

Log in to the Rapid Cortex admin dashboard

Go to app.rapidcortex.us and sign in with your admin account.

2

Navigate to QR & NFC Codes

From the sidebar, select your agency, then click “QR & NFC Codes.” RC platform admins go to RC Admin → Agencies → [Agency] → QR & NFC Codes.

3

Click “+ New Code”

Enter the name and location of this sign (e.g., “McKinley Hall — 3rd Floor”), select the report type, and click Save.

4

Copy the NFC URL

Click the “Copy NFC URL” button. The URL looks like: <https://app.rapidcortex.us/report/ABC123>. Keep it copied — you will paste it into NFC Tools in the next section.

WARNING Create a separate code for each physical sign location. Do not reuse the same URL across multiple locations — you will not be able to tell which location a report came from.

2

Program the NFC Tag

Use the free NFC Tools app to write the URL to the tag

This takes about 10 seconds per tag once you know the steps. You only need to do this once per tag.

1

Download NFC Tools (free)

Search “NFC Tools” in the App Store (iOS) or Google Play (Android). The publisher is wakdev. It is free — no account required.

2

Open NFC Tools and tap “Write”

On the main screen, tap the “Write” tab at the bottom.

3

Tap “Add a record” then “URL / URI”

A list of record types will appear. Select “URL / URI” from the list.

4

Paste the URL and tap OK

Paste the URL you copied from the Rapid Cortex dashboard. The URL field should look like: <https://app.rapidcortex.us/report/ABC123>. Tap OK.

5**Tap “Write / xx Bytes”**

The app will show a button with the byte size of your record (e.g., “Write / 38 Bytes”). Tap it.

6**Hold the NFC tag to the back of your phone**

Place an unprogrammed NTAG213 sticker against the back of your phone near the top (iPhone) or center (Android). Hold it still. The app will say “Write complete.”

TIP If the write fails, try moving the tag slowly around the back of your phone until you find the NFC antenna location. On iPhone, it is near the top edge. On Android, it is usually in the center.

NOTE If you are programming multiple tags for the same location, you can write the same URL to as many tags as you need without going back to the dashboard. Each tap on a tag will be counted separately.

3

Test the Tag Before Attaching

Always test before mounting — you cannot reprogram a tag once it is under a sign

Testing takes 30 seconds and prevents having to remove a mounted tag if something goes wrong.

1

Lock your phone screen, then hold the tag to the back

The phone must be awake (screen on). Hold the programmed tag to the NFC location on the back of your phone without opening any app.

2

A notification should appear at the top of your screen

Your phone will show a banner or prompt saying the tag was detected. Tap it.

3

The Rapid Cortex report form should open in your browser

You should see the safety reporting form for your location. The page header will show the vertical (Campus Security, Venue Security, etc.).

4

Check the Rapid Cortex dashboard

After tapping, log in to the admin dashboard and confirm that the NFC Tap Count for this code has increased by 1.

CAUTION

If the form does not open: confirm that NFC is enabled on your phone (Settings → NFC), check that the URL was pasted correctly in NFC Tools, and make sure you are holding the tag in the right position.

4

Attach the Tag to the Sign

Peel, stick, and you are done

1

Label the tag (optional but recommended)

Before peeling, use a permanent marker to write the location name on the white front of the tag (e.g., “MH-3F” for McKinley Hall 3rd Floor). This helps if you ever need to identify a tag that has come loose.

2

Clean the mounting surface (optional)

Wipe the back of the sign with an isopropyl alcohol wipe and let it dry for 30 seconds. This ensures a stronger bond. Skip this step if the surface is already clean.

3

Peel the backing and press firmly onto the back of the sign

Center the tag on the back of the sign. Press firmly for 10–15 seconds. The adhesive sets within a few minutes.

4

Mount the sign

Install the sign in its final location. The NFC tag is now live. Anyone with a smartphone can tap the front of the sign to report.

5**Do a final tap test after mounting**

Hold your phone to the front of the mounted sign where the tag is on the back. Confirm the form still opens correctly at the installed location.

Sign Material Compatibility

NFC works differently depending on what the sign is made of.

Material	NFC Works?	Notes
Acrylic / Plexiglass	✓ Yes	Best option. Tag reads clearly through any thickness.
PVC / Foam Board	✓ Yes	Reads through up to 1/2 inch thickness.
Plastic	✓ Yes	Works on any non-metallic plastic.
Wood	✓ Yes	Works through standard sign thickness.
Glass	✓ Yes	Reads through glass. Stick tag to inner surface.
Aluminum (face)	⚠ Partial	Aluminum blocks NFC. Mount tag on the face (not back) in a corner, or use a mounting block.
Solid metal back	✗ No	Metal completely blocks the signal. Use a non-metallic mounting plate between tag and metal, or attach to a non-metal surface nearby.

5

Troubleshooting

Common issues and how to fix them

Problem	Solution
Phone does not detect the tag at all	Check that NFC is enabled: iPhone → Control Center → NFC icon. Android → Settings → Connected Devices → NFC. Move the tag slowly across the back of the phone to find the antenna.
Tag detected but wrong page opens	The tag was programmed with the wrong URL. Write the correct URL again using NFC Tools — you can overwrite an NTAG213 tag with a new URL at any time.
Tag detected but no page opens	Check that the URL begins with https://. Some phones require the full URL protocol. Re-write the tag in NFC Tools, making sure the URL field shows https:// at the start.
Tag stopped working after sign was mounted	The tag may be too close to a metal surface. Move it to a non-metallic area of the sign, or use an on-metal NFC tag (sold separately, labeled “anti-metal” or “on-metal NFC”).
Tap count not updating in dashboard	The engagement is tracked when the reporting form loads. If the report page is blocked or times out, the count will not increment. Check your internet connection at the sign location.
Sign shows correct form but wrong location name	Go to the Rapid Cortex dashboard, find this QR code record, and update the Zone Name field. Changes take effect immediately without reprogramming the tag.
Tag adhesive came loose	Clean the surface with isopropyl alcohol, let dry fully, and re-stick the tag. For permanent installations, use a small amount of clear super glue around the tag edge.

6

Quick Reference Card

Print and keep with your NFC tag supplies

Supplies Checklist ☐ NTAG213 NFC sticker tags ☐ Smartphone with NFC ☐ NFC Tools app (wakdev, free) ☐ Reporting URL from RC dashboard ☐ Permanent marker (optional) ☐ Isopropyl wipes (optional)	Installation Steps 1. Get URL from RC dashboard 2. Open NFC Tools → Write → Add Record → URL 3. Paste URL → OK → Write 4. Hold tag to back of phone 5. Test tap — confirm form opens 6. Label tag with location name 7. Clean sign surface 8. Peel and stick to back of sign 9. Mount sign 10. Final tap test after mounting
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Need Help?

Contact Rapid Cortex Support

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